1 The round and rolling

The round

1 **The GM telegraphs** everything, face up: what, at whom (their Body, Mind or Soul), how hard.	**2** **Players act**, in any order, one action each: answer one telegraph, put your action into a friend's answer, or spend it on something else.	**3** **The round ends.** Unanswered telegraphs land, clocks and events nobody worked step down, and so does every condition.

Your action

- One a round: act, answer a telegraph, Defend, move past your stride, pull something from your bag, break a condition, take a breath (your Confidence comes up a size, as far as d6), or lead if you're a Leader. Your stride, a few words, dropping something or putting it away, and pumping Aura into your attuned thing are free. Intercepting costs 1 Aura but no action.
- **Extra actions:** 3 Aura each, up to one action a round for each archetype you've got, counting the one everybody gets · hold it (just your stride this round) and you've got two next round · coming out of hiding, one even if you're *Unseen* as well · the Boon, or a trait that says so.
- **Lead** (the Leader's): build an order or a rallying song and hand its steps to friends who can hear or see you, this round. They don't have to fit, and they don't bring a split.
- Outside a round, it's one action for a quick go, two if you can take your time.

Building the roll

- Pick the Root that fits how you're doing it (Body, Mind or Soul) and the specialty that fits what. Add them up, and add 1 for each item you're using that fits.
- A specialty you have to make a case for is 1 Aura. Anything else that fits is 1 Aura each to bring in, a step each. Going beyond what something normally does is 1 Aura, sword or spell.
- Two sides a step, up to a d12. Past 6 steps, more dice. Every roll's at least 1 step, a d2.
- After you roll, your archetype's Push puts +2 on one die of its mechanic, for 1 of its home track, if you need it.

Steps into dice

1 STEP	2 STEPS	3 STEPS	4 STEPS	5 STEPS	6 STEPS	7 STEPS	8 STEPS	9 STEPS	10 STEPS	11 STEPS	12 STEPS	18 STEPS	24 STEPS
d2	d4	d6	d8	d10	d12	d12+d2	d12+d4	d12+d6	d12+d8	d12+d10	2d12	3d12	4d12

The roll

- You roll the threat's die too, in another colour. The GM almost never rolls in a round.
- A threat rolls its defence once a round, the first time anyone goes at it, and every die at it that round has to beat that roll.
- **Beat it:** you did it. **Tie:** the defender wins (you when it comes at you, them when you act), but if you're acting, answering included, 1 Aura wins it. An Illusionist meets or beats. **Under:** you didn't, and it only costs you when it matters.
- **Aura:** 1 for every die of yours that wins, and 1 for every top face, defence included. Not for a summon's die, a die something added to after you rolled, a number an Oracle swapped in or a flipped die.
- **Failed?** 1 Resolve rerolls it, all your dice or just one. The threat's dice stay where they landed.

Intents

- Every die gets an intent and a target before you roll. Several dice on one intent is advantage: your best die counts. Dice never add, except when you move, when a Warrior's dice explode, and when an ability or an awakening adds to one.
- **Splits:** one for every action in the roll, and dice past 6 steps are already separate, so 8 steps on one action can be a d6, a d6 and a d4. Each die has its own intent. You can share your steps between the dice you've got.
- **Area** (the Elementalist's): one die can be how far instead of an intent: a burst (that many squares out from a point), a cone (that long, and as wide at the end) or a line (twice as far). It takes a split and costs no Aura, and you can always make it smaller. No grid: 1 to 2 is close, 3 to 5 a few steps, 6 or more the whole room. *Sweep* weapons get one die at everyone in reach, free, whoever's holding them.

Combos

- **Combo:** two or more actions into the same thing at the same time, yours or your friends'. One Root, whoever rolls, and every action brings its specialty and the items it's using. No Aura. The same specialty from two of you counts for each. Whoever rolls takes the Aura. Your own extra action brings in another specialty (Knives with Stealth), or the same one again for +1.

Moving

- Stride 3, free, before, between or after your action. A Move action rolls your Body and whatever makes you fast here for extra squares, and those dice add. A Teleporter's stride can be a teleport of up to 10 units.
- Difficult ground costs 2 a square. Diagonals count as one. There are no opportunity attacks. Cover is line of sight, and it doesn't add steps.
- Close 1 · Reach 2 · Near · Far · Beyond. No grid? Close, Reach and Near are within your stride, Far takes a Move action, and Beyond takes more than a round.
- Weapon properties: Reach · Thrown · Ranged · Long · Grapple · Sweep · Piercing · Breaker · Charge · Concealed · Quick · Two-Handed · Reload.

2 The tracks and defence

Stamina *Body*



starts here *a hit at d2*

Confidence *Mind*



starts here *a hit at d2*

Resolve *Soul*



starts here *a hit at d2*

The tracks

- **Stamina** (Body), **Confidence** (Mind) and **Resolve** (Soul). Each starts at d12, and every hit that gets through to that Root drops it a size, as far as d2. A hit that gets through at d2, and you Blaze.
- **They're your defence:** when the telegraphs land, each track rolls once against what's at its Root, and each die stops one it beats or ties. The more you've taken, the smaller you're defending with.
- **They pay:** an ability's 1 from its archetype's home track, or 2 from your other two. A reroll's 1 Resolve. Paying never takes a track below d2.
- **2 for 1:** when a hit gets through, pay 2 from your other two tracks, in any mix, and the one it's at stays put.
- **They come back:** at the end of every scene, roll each track below d12, and a 4 or more puts it up a size. A d2 can't come back till downtime. Every downtime starts with each track up a size, and a healing slot puts 6 sizes back. A big bite from a Catch or a hostile thread, or straining a bond thread, puts your Resolve up a size.
- **Blaze:** declare something extraordinary, and it happens, no roll. You can choose to die. If you don't, leave the scene, and that track takes a Scar: a Catch, and its smallest open size is locked for good. A Scar that would lock a track's last size is your last Blaze. Nobody Blazes on purpose.
- **Heal** (the Healer's): an action, and each die that rolls a 4 or more puts one of the patient's tracks up a size. It reaches one person, and a split can reach a second person you can touch. **Quick heal**, for anyone: 1 Aura and your action puts one of someone's tracks up a size, no roll.

Telegraphs and defence

- **Body, Mind or Soul:** blows and teeth are at your Body, fear, lies and pressure at your Mind, and despair, temptation and curses at your Soul.
- **Answer:** your action against its dice, built from what fits how you stop it, and friends can join in. Win and it's stopped. Lose and it lands at once, with no defence roll. A tie's a loss unless you pay 1 Aura. You can answer for a friend, and if you stepped in the way and lose, it lands on you.
- **Let it ride:** whatever you don't answer lands at the end of the round. Roll each track once against what's at its Root, and each die stops one telegraph it beats or ties. Everything else gets through.
- **Defend:** your action. When they land, roll a Root and a specialty that fit how you're defending, armour and shield as items, on top of your tracks. Each die stops one it beats or ties, as long as how you're defending fits it.
- **Intercept:** 1 Aura and no action. Take the blows at a friend's Body within your stride, and your Stamina handles them. A Guardian does it free, for every friend within his stride, and so does a summon. Nobody can intercept what's at a Mind or a Soul.
- **One die at each of you** from each threat, unless a tag like *Flurry* says it can do more.
- **Running doesn't dodge.** One aimed at you lands wherever you've gone. Only one aimed at a place can be walked out of.
- At a stake, a place or a clock there's no defence. Unanswered, it happens.

Consequences: the GM names one

A hit, a size off the track it's at · a box on your armour on that Root, or something else you carry breaks (attuned things can't break) · Aspiration down · Party Goal down · a clock ticks. You can offer another that fits and costs about as much, and 2 for 1 from your other tracks always fits. A specific intent happens unless you take the hit on your track instead. A one-answer telegraph can't be traded.

Conditions

- A tag with a die, the die that placed it, for you or against you. Passive: one step, or for a few, like *Prone* and *Exposed*, a vulnerability. Active: spend it, free, for its big effect.
- A condition you put on a friend, like a ward or a blessing, goes on one friend at the die you built. The second die of a split can put it on another friend you can touch.
- It steps down a size every round, and it's gone past d2. Break it with an action that beats its die. One of each on a target, and the same one goes on once a round. Placed again later, the new one replaces it.
- On a threat, spending *Burning*, *Bleeding* or *Poisoned* strips a tag with no roll (on a multiplier, it ticks one off), and a lost action is a telegraph gone.
- *Marked* is the Hunter's. It gives no step and nobody spends it: anyone who acts against whatever's *Marked* rolls the Mark die too. When what it's on falls, the Mark jumps to another creature the Hunter can see.

3 Aura, archetypes and threads

Aura

Up to your maximum, 5 to start. You're full every scene, and there's none in downtime. While you're acting it can go past your maximum, and once you've finished acting for the round, anything over is gone. Off your turn it stops at your maximum, and you can give the rest to a friend in the scene.

SPEND 1

- Bring something in, a friend's specialty through a thread too
- Make a case for a specialty, or go beyond
- Keep a Catch quiet, or turn it your way
- Win a tie when you're acting
- A quick heal
- Intercept for a friend within your stride
- Pump it into your attuned thing

GET 1 BACK

- Every die of yours that wins
- Every top face
- Letting a Catch bite, as often as you like, as long as it's real trouble
- Bringing real trouble on yourself with no Catch
- Your attuned thing's own way
- A great setup that didn't land, if the GM says so
- Traits and Boons that say so

Spend 3: an extra action, up to one a round for each archetype you've got.

Traits are free, and they're never a step, so you never bring one in.

The archetypes

Each ability's 1 from the archetype's home track, or 2 from your other two, and they stack. Most have a Push: +2 on one die of the mechanic after you roll, and +3 if you've taken it twice. The whole of each one is in The Archetypes.

Bard: (Resolve) your action has every friend who can hear you roll their Confidence, up a size on a 4 or more, as far as d10, or your song's a Defend against fear for all of them, with as many splits as you like.

Bloodsworn: (Stamina) every size your Stamina drops adds 3 steps to your action, and you can pay it on purpose.

Elementalist: (Resolve) one of your dice can be an area, a burst, a cone or a line, and it costs no Aura.

Face: (Confidence) build your dice but don't roll them, and put them on a threat as influence. Roll them against one of its telegraphs before it lands, and each of its dice your best one beats does what you say.

Gambler: (Confidence) once a round, flip any die you can see after it lands: its size plus 1, take away what it rolled.

Guardian: (Stamina) you intercept blows for free, for every friend within your stride, whoever they're from.

Healer: (Resolve) the only one who makes a heal roll: each die on a 4 or more puts a track up a size.

Hunter: (Confidence) mark a creature, and anyone who acts against it rolls your Mark die too. When it falls, the Mark jumps to another.

Illusionist: (Confidence) meet or beat the threats' Challenge, and they believe your illusion until they interact with it or try to get through it.

Leader: (Resolve) an order or a rallying song hands its steps to friends who can hear or see you.

Maker: (Stamina) roll against an item's size, and every die that beats it gives the item a tag for the scene. You can pump Aura into a friend's attuned thing.

Oracle: (Confidence) roll your action as foresight, then swap those numbers into anyone's dice before the round ends, as long as each one fits the die.

Scholar: (Confidence) win a Study and introduce a truth, a step for the crew this scene.

Shadow: (Stamina) the dice you hide with go into your shadow pool, to add to any roll after that.

Shifter: (Stamina) catch animal tags against their die, and keep them until downtime.

Summoner: (Resolve) the only one who catches souls and summons them.

Teleporter: (Resolve) your stride can be a teleport of up to 10 units, and 1 Resolve opens a portal.

Warrior: (Stamina) your dice explode in a fight, so a top face rolls again and adds on.

Bonds and threads

- A bond's usually a person, but it can be a faction, a place or a cause. Each thread is one truth between you, and it's a **bond thread**, something good, or a **hostile thread**, something gone bad. Either can be strained, which means nearly snapped, and with no thread at all you're neutral. Each person's one bond, with all your threads with them under it.
- **To start:** two bond threads with the crew, from your answers in Connect. Write a hostile thread too and you can write a third bond thread, and three's the most.
- **Borrow** through a bond thread: 1 Aura brings something of theirs into your roll as a step (a faction's, one of its assets), and it doesn't strain anything. Not while it's strained.
- **Strain** a bond thread: lean on them in the story and your Resolve comes up a size. It's free and takes no action, and the thread's strained. One with someone in the crew is strained for both of you.
- **Mend:** make it right with them, in downtime or in a scene with them (not the fight where you strained it), and it's whole again.
- **Snap:** strain it again before it's mended. Your Resolve still comes up, but cross the thread out. When the last one goes, so does the bond.
- **A hostile thread** bites like a Catch: when it brings you real trouble, 1 Aura, or a size of Resolve for a big bite. Doing right by them strains it, and doing it again snaps it.

4 Your character, downtime, threats and gear

Your character

- **Titles:** two to start. Each one's 1 on a Root and 1 on each of three specialties that fit it, and holds three permissions to start, six at most.
- **Permissions:** a doing word and how, what or where, like *climb sheer walls*. Each one's 1 on a Root and 1 on a specialty, and it fits both. You need a magic permission or a magic item to do magic at all, and magic's written narrow.
- **Roots and specialties:** add them up. A specialty's something you could be known for or teach, and you name it. A roll's one Root and one specialty, plus the items you're using.
- **Archetypes:** two to start, apart from your Titles, and you can take the same one twice. Each one's a mechanic and its abilities, and you can have one action a round for each archetype, so two let you buy one.
- **Traits:** two, and Grow can give you more. Each one's passive: always on, or it fires by itself when something happens. It's never a step.
- **Boons:** two permission slots on a Title buy one. Burdens only come on attuned things. The menu's in Boons and Burdens.
- **Aspiration:** starts at d2 and climbs. An action when it's within reach, or a slot. One step a roll. Past d12, take a new Title, archetype or attuned thing.
- **To start:** 5 Aura, Stamina, Confidence and Resolve at d12, a stride of 3, one attuned thing, and two bond threads with the crew.

Things that climb

- Things that climb (the Goal, Aspirations, projects, agendas) start low, step up on a win, one step a roll, and past d12 they're done.

Downtime

- Four pressures: personal, party, faction, world. Ignore one and it gets worse, and twice makes it a scene. Every faction's action is telegraphed at the start, and rolled after the slots.
- Two personal slots each, and the crew takes one action, like any faction. A personal slot can go into the crew's action. Every downtime starts with each of your tracks up a size.
- **Recover:** heal, 6 sizes back on your tracks however you like · mend something broken, or a piece of armour with boxes ticked. **Grow:** a new permission on a Title · a new trait or thread · chase your Aspiration · get something.
- **Mend a thread** you've strained by making it right with them. Downtime's one place for it, and a scene with them is the other.
- **Swap** a permission for another that fits your Title, or two for a Boon, and back. **Attune:** a slot for each new awakening, and the material for a new stage. A soul you're carrying goes into your summoning attunement.
- Ties go to the defender. No Aura: pay 1 Resolve to roll your dice again, or an extra crew resource to take the tie.

Threats

- Challenge 2 (d4) nuisance · 3 (d6) a real fight · 4 (d8) capable · 5 (d10) serious · 6 (d12) the top. It defends and telegraphs with its Challenge die, and that never steps down unless a tag says so. A tag only changes dice when it says so.
- Keeps-it-going tags are its health, and a multiplier, like *Armoured ×4*, is how many wins one takes. Mook: none or one. Named: two. Boss: three or more, multipliers on the big ones, and a weak point. *(first)* means nothing under it can be stripped till it's gone. *Layered* (special encounters only): one die for every one left, rolled the first time it's attacked in a round, and the best one stands.
- A win: strip a tag, or tick one off its multiplier · take it down · a condition · move it · learn something · stop a telegraph. An opening: one win ends a Mook or Named, and a Boss loses two whole tags (only its weak point ends it).
- **Vulnerabilities:** each one that fits a win that strips a tag or lands a hit adds one more tick, and you choose where it goes: the same tag, or another one the hit could reach, so one vulnerability can strip two plain tags. On you, it's one more size off the track. The same one never counts twice. *Prone* and *Exposed* are vulnerabilities, and a hidden one's a hidden tag.
- **Forms:** when a form's last keeps-it-going tag goes, it changes. It takes 3 to 5 tags from its Forms list, and its multipliers come back on whichever of them matter most. Its weak point ends it in any form.

Study

Roll against its Challenge. Win, and pick one: a hidden tag · a straight answer. A Scholar can introduce a truth instead: say something that wasn't obvious to anyone else, and it's true, and it's a step for the crew this scene.

Stakes, clocks, events

- A stake: Challenge + tags in the way. Strip them all and it's yours.
- A clock steps down each round nobody works the stake. An event steps down each round nobody touches it. Past d2, it happens.
- Every scene gets a scene clock: past d2, the scene turns.

Chases

The Gap (past d2: caught, past d12: away) · The Pursuer (past d2: shaken off) · The Ground (past d2: the world wins). The Gap and the Ground step down each round unless someone changed them.

What you carry

- 3 equipment (what you wear or wield), 3 utility (tools, and things you use up and cross off) and a keepsake. A bag holds 10 more. Getting something out takes your action, and putting it away's free.
- A plain item's 1 more on a roll you're using it in, to your specialty or as one of its own, and never a Root. A purse of gold is a utility item, about a month's wages.
- **Armour** sits on a Root: Body (leathers, plate, shields, helmets), Mind (clothes that fit the scene) or Soul (a holy symbol, a ward). Offer it when a hit gets through there and tick a box instead. Common has 1 box, Fine 2 and Masterwork 3, it breaks when the last one goes, and it's 1 more when you Defend till then. You start with Common, and one piece can be Fine.
- **Attunement:** one attuned thing to start, on top of what you carry, and attuned things can't break. It's an item, it gets you Aura its own way, and it has awakenings. A passive one holds up to 2 Aura, pumped in free while you're acting, and works for as much as it holds. An active one spends Aura when you use it, more for more. It all empties at the end of the scene. Awakened: 1 awakening, or 2 with a Catch. Tempered: 2, or 4 with a Burden. Perfected: 3, or 6 with a Burden and a Catch. Each stage needs a material, and each new awakening a downtime slot.

Summoning

- Only a Summoner catches souls and summons them. A summoning attunement holds souls, one to an awakening, on the same ladder. Starting souls are d4s.
- **Catch one:** when a creature falls, spend your action and roll against its Challenge. Beat it and its soul goes in a utility slot, with its Challenge die, and into your attunement in downtime. Miss and it's gone.
- **Call them out:** spend Aura on a soul as part of your action, with a reason in the story. Each Aura's a d4 of summons, built into one or several, none bigger than the soul's own die.
- A summon acts like anyone and rolls its own die. It drops a size every round and for every hit that gets through, and past d2 it's gone, back in your attunement. It intercepts for free and rolls its die to stop one of the dice it took. A horde rolls as one throw. Summons can't combo, and their dice never give Aura. They all go back at the end of the scene.